other districts of Karnataka, barring Bangalore, on the Human Development Index.[16] Migration is an important reason behind this relative prosperity.

Several decades before the establishment of McDonald's in the US, the Udupi fast food restaurant model began to spread its tentacles around India. Eventually, it breached national boundaries and reached key Indian diasporic hotspots around the world. Expansion did not occur through franchises but migration and community networks.

Migration avenues have widened in recent years to include more destinations and occupations, including the underworld, but the intensity of mass male migration from coastal Karnataka continues unabated. Ironically, the region's two most famous migrant personalities are not men but women —Bollywood actors Aishwarya Rai and Shilpa Shetty, both of whom were born in Tulu-speaking Bunt families in Mangalore, just south of Udupi.

Density and Destiny: Saran in Bihar

Perhaps no other region in India evokes such a picture of migration in contemporary and historic times as Bihar. Situated in the lower part of the Gangetic plain, it has witnessed the rise and fall of some of the greatest dynastic civilizations in Indian history. The cities of yore, including Pataliputra, now Patna, would have drawn numerous migrants over many centuries, at least since the 4th century BCE. South of Patna, the famed Buddhist monastery at Nalanda attracted students from as far as China for several centuries in the first millennium CE. Over the next millennium, secure with water supply in the Gangetic basin and safe from the periodic wars around Delhi, the population of Bihar grew steadily under different rulers. Continuous habitation over time led to high population densities, particularly in the Bhojpuri-speaking part of modern-day west Bihar and east Uttar Pradesh. By the late 19th century, districts in this region were among the densest rural tracts of the world. Saran district, located west of Patna, emerged as the leader of the pack.[17]

It is possible to trace outmigration from Saran and its surrounding regions to as far back as the 15th century. The historian Dirk Kolff has